

Letter Twenty-Nine

NO ECUMENICAL COUNCIL
WITHOUT THE POPE'S APPROVAL

Dear Euthymios,

You quote from Bishop Kallistos Ware of Diokleia's book *The Orthodox Church*, which gives the common Eastern Orthodox teaching that "the [ecumenical] council is the chief organ whereby God has chosen to guide His people. . . . In matters of faith, the final decision" rests "not with the Pope alone, but with a council representing all the bishops of the Church."¹ Certainly, a council of *all* the Church's bishops, under the leadership of the Pope who confirms their gathering as ecumenical, is the bearer of the supreme authority of the Church. Likewise with many bishops who gather and act together in council with the Pope, who similarly confirms their council as ecumenical. *However*, when an ecumenical council is not in session and enacting decrees that affect the Church's doctrine and discipline, is there no supreme authority that exists in the Church? If so, how can the Church *universally* resolve disputes over doctrine and discipline *in the absence of an ecumenical council*, and thus foster and maintain the unity for which Jesus prayed for his Church (John 17:20-23)? Indeed, how can there exist, in Bishop Kallistos's words, the Church as "a single visible society which alone can claim to be the one true Church," if there is not present in *every age* that

¹ Ware, *The Orthodox Church*, 15, 49.

supreme authority—a visible head, in other words—who gives that society its visible coherence and identifies it as the true Church of Jesus Christ?

In addition, when schisms and heresies undermine the Gospel, who ensures that a council is truly ecumenical in combatting them? Bishop Theodore Abū-Qurrah of Haran,² an Eastern bishop writing around 820, states that the Church has always had divinely ensured recourse to Rome:

By the grace of the Holy Spirit, in every circumstance our recourse is simply to build ourselves on the foundation of St. Peter, who administered the holy councils which were convened by order of the Bishop of Rome, the capital of the world. Whoever is established on her throne is the one entrusted by Christ to turn to the people of the Church his ecumenical council, and to confirm them, as we have established in a number of other places.³

The Doctors and other authentic spiritual guides of Eastern Christianity opposed the basic Caesaropapist vision of the Church, which some Byzantines developed. Consider another remarkable witness to papal supremacy vis-à-vis ecumenical councils that represents the authentic Eastern tradition. These words of St. Methodius,⁴ the Apostle of the Slavs in the 800s, were placed in the first Slavonic edition of the Greek *Nomocanon* (“Canon law”), the original Greek version of which is attributed to John the Scholastic, the Patriarch of Constantinople from 565–567. St. Methodius’s words constitute a commentary on the infamous canon twenty-eight of the Ecumenical Council of Chalcedon (451), which I’ve previously refuted as “proof” that the ancient Church did not recognize Rome’s supreme jurisdiction.

² A region associated with modern-day southeastern Turkey.

³ Theodore Abū Qurrah, *On the Death of Christ*, quoted in *Theodore Abū Qurrah*, trans. John C. Lamoreaux (Provo, UT: Brigham Young University Press, 2005), 128.

⁴ Or of a close disciple.

Canon twenty-eight was originally passed at Chalcedon to expand the jurisdiction of Constantinople in the East. Centuries later, in his day, St. Methodius wrote to correct an attempt to invoke the canon as evidence the Pope didn't have universal and supreme jurisdiction in overseeing the Church. Pope Leo the Great, as I noted in a previous letter to you, Euthymios, was even asked by the Council Fathers at Chalcedon to confirm canon twenty-eight! And, as I also noted to you, the Pope rather chose to protest and quash it "by the authority of the blessed Apostle Peter."⁵ As the Methodian commentary affirms:

It is necessary to know that this decision (canon twenty-eight) was not accepted by Pope Leo I. . . . And it is not true, as this canon affirms, that the holy Fathers have accorded the primacy and honor to Old Rome because it was the capital of the empire. But it is from on high that it began; it is of grace divine that this primacy has derived its origin. Peter, the most exalted of the apostles, heard from the mouth of Our Lord these words: "Peter, do you love me? . . . Feed my sheep" [John 21:17]. This is why he possesses among the hierarchs the preeminent rank and the first see. It is notorious, besides, that, although emperors have dwelt at Milan and Ravenna, and their palaces are found there to our own day, these cities have not received on that account the primacy. For the dignity and preeminence of the priestly hierarchy have not been established by the favor of the civil power, but by divine choice and by apostolic authority. . . .

How would it be possible, because of an earthly emperor, to displace divine gifts and apostolic privileges, and to introduce innovations into the prescriptions of the immaculate Faith? Immovable, indeed, unto the end are the privileges of Old Rome. So, insofar as being set

⁵ Pope St. Leo I, Epist. 105.

over all the churches, the Pontiff of Rome has no need to betake himself to all the holy ecumenical councils, but without his participation manifested by the sending of his subordinates, every ecumenical council is non-existent and it is he who renders legal everything that has been decided in the Council.⁶

In 1959, the Greek Orthodox lay theologian Basil Moustakis wrote with refreshing candor:

The primacy of the Bishop of Rome is an indisputable historical fact. No scientific or ecclesiastical value can be attached to the attempts of the anti-papal critics to cast doubt upon this evident truth. . . . Hence primacy as such should not be looked upon as an obstacle to reunion.⁷

Even more to the point, Euthymios, Mr. Moustakis defended the concept of papal infallibility, and saw no obstacle to the union of the Churches in the *Filioque*, Purgatory, or the Marian dogmas of the Immaculate Conception and Assumption of the Mother of God.

I am obliged to say, Euthymios, that the Eastern Orthodox materials you have forwarded to me betray a warped and superficial understanding of the Pope's role in the Church. I suggest to you that this is due to the following:

1. An unwarranted and jaundiced view of the Pope as an arbitrary and absolute monarch or despot, thereby resulting in a gross caricature of the papacy;
2. Their view of primacy and collegiality (or conciliarity) as irreconcilable opposites; and

⁶ St. Methodius, in Nicholas Brian-Chaninov, *The Russian Church* (London: Burns, Oates & Washbourne, 1931), 46.

⁷ Basil Moustakis, *Vers l'Unité Chrétienne*, April 1960.

3. Their failure to see that their cherished concept of a historic "undivided Church" logically implies the existence of an indefectible "center of unity" in and for the episcopate.

May I comment further, Euthymios, on each of the above.

As to (1), the Catholic Church affirms, without any equivocation, that the only absolute monarch in the Church is Christ Himself. The Pope as the Successor of Peter and visible head of the Church Militant is obliged to abide by the dicta of Scripture and Tradition, the doctrinal definitions of ecumenical councils, and the Church's canons legislated for the common good of the faithful.⁸ His doctrinal definitions and judgments reflect the consensus of the collegial structure of the Church's hierarchy, though a Pope is certainly not infallible when speaking or even teaching in a non-definitive manner. With respect to addressing doctrinal and disciplinary questions, the Petrine ministry of the Pope does not ignore the calling of local synods and world synods of bishops, nor does it ignore consulting patriarchs and bishops, eminent theologians, members of the Pope's college of cardinals, and even learned laity. In addition, although Eastern Orthodox leaders often state that an ecumenical council is the only supreme authority in the Church, it is undeniable that they have been unable to hold *even one* since their schism with the Chair of Peter. Some Eastern Orthodox even hold that there cannot be an ecumenical council *unless the Pope participates in such a gathering*. The confusion and contradictions that exist among Eastern Orthodox about holding an ecumenical council is not surprising, given that only the Pope, as the visible head of the hierarchy, possesses the divine authority to convoke or confirm one! As late as the Council of Florence (1439), the Byzantine Greeks reflected the continuing strength Caesaropapism had among them, as they defended the claim that only the Byzantine emperor had the right to convoke an

⁸ However, a Pope is empowered by Jesus to modify changeable discipline (Matt 28:18-19).

ecumenical council. At Florence, it was the emperor, moreover, who determined the theological issues that could be discussed by the Byzantine prelates in their discussions with the Latins.

As to (2), Christ arranged for both primacy and collegiality in His Church. They are complementary, since both the papacy and the episcopate are necessary for the mission of the Church. Collegiality (or conciliarity) is rendered meaningless if there is no head of the College of Bishops who can arrange for collegial action, such as convoking an ecumenical council. Both Catholics and Eastern Orthodox believe that the body of bishops who constitute the episcopate are successors to the Apostolic College, yet the hierarchical structure and operation of the separated Eastern churches reveals the impact of the absence of Peter's headship. An episcopate of patriarchs and bishops minus Peter, the chief and leader of the apostles, cannot adequately reproduce the Apostolic College, given the mission to "teach all nations" (see Matt 28:19). As the ancient Fathers of the Church acknowledged, the Bishop of Rome is the primate of the Church and its supreme teacher, who—in the words of Pope St. Gregory the Great—should rule as "servant of the servants of God."⁹ It was the same Pope St. Gregory the Great who wrote concerning the universal jurisdiction of his See, "As to what they say of the Church of Constantinople, who doubts that it is subject to the Apostolic See?"¹⁰ The words of St. Jerome (342–420) also strike at the heart of the incomplete ecclesiology of Eastern Orthodox Christians. These are not words, Euthymios, which are found in the attacks on papal primacy that you have sent me:

⁹ Pope St. Gregory the Great, *Epistles* bk. 1, letter 36, trans. James Barmby, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 12, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature, 1895), rev. and ed. Kevin Knight, New Advent, <http://www.newadvent.org/fathers/360201036.htm>.

¹⁰ Pope St. Gregory the Great, *Epistles* bk. 9, Letter 12, quoted in Fr. Horace Kinder Mann, *The Lives of the Popes in the Early Middle Ages*, vol. 1, pt. 1 (London: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trubner, 1902), 135.

But you say, the Church was founded upon Peter; although elsewhere the same is attributed to all the apostles, and they all receive the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and the strength of the Church depends upon them all alike, yet one among the Twelve is chosen so that when a head has been appointed, there may be no occasion for schism.¹¹

As to (3), consider the witness of St. Optatus, who served as a great opponent of the Donatist Schism in North Africa, one who wrote even before St. Augustine. Optatus was the Bishop of Milevis, a region which roughly corresponds to modern western Tunisia and eastern Algeria. The Donatists had “made a confusion of everything,” so Optatus sought to answer faithfully the question they raised: “Where is the one Church that is truly “catholic and apostolic?” In his remarkable fourth-century treatise *Against the Donatists* (ca. 370), Optatus emphasized that the true Church is, first, one which is all over the world (i.e., truly *ubique* or “universal/everywhere”¹²) as “catholic” means. Second, the Church Jesus founded is the one whose children are in full communion with the See of Peter, the See of the head of the apostles, to whom Christ alone committed the keys of the kingdom of heaven,¹³ and so against whom to contend is “an audacious sacrilege”:

¹¹ St. Jerome, *Against Jovinianus* bk. 1, ch. 26, trans. W. H. Fremantle, G. Lewis, and W. G. Martley, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, vol. 6, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature, 1893), rev. and ed. Kevin Knight, New Advent, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/30091.htm>.

¹² St. Optatus, *Against the Donatists*, bk. 2, ch. 1, in *The Work of St. Optatus, Bishop of Milevis, Against the Donatists* (London: Longman, 1917) as given at <https://verbum.com/product/38878/the-work-of-st-optatus-bishop-of-milevis-against-the-donatists>.

¹³ To be clear, St. Jerome on the one hand, and St. Optatus (see below) and I on the other, do not fundamentally disagree about the keys of the kingdom in the leadership of Christ's Church. According to the scriptural account in Matthew, *only Peter explicitly* received the keys from Jesus, consistent otherwise with the divine primacy of Peter and his successors, and consistent also with the prime minister who served in the Old Covenant kingdom of David (see Isa 22:15–25).

You cannot then deny that you do know that upon Peter first in the City of Rome was bestowed the episcopal *Cathedra* [chair], upon which sat Peter, the head of all the apostles (for which reason he was called “Cephas”), that, in this one *Cathedra*, unity should be preserved by all, lest the other apostles might claim—each for himself—separate *cathedras*, so that he who should set up a second *cathedra* against the unique *Cathedra* would already be a schismatic and a sinner. . . . We read that Peter received the saving keys—Peter, that is to say, the first of our line, to whom it was said by Christ, “To thee will I give the keys of the kingdom of heaven” [Matt 16:19], and these keys “the gates of hell shall not overcome” [Matt 16:18]. How is it, then, that you strive to usurp for yourselves the keys of the kingdom of heaven, you who, with your arguments, and audacious sacrilege, war against the Chair of Peter?¹⁴

In defending their separation from the great Catholic communion, St. Optatus accused the Donatist schismatics of “audacious sacrilege” in “warring against the Chair of Peter,” and, in fact, setting up a “Chair of Pestilence”¹⁵ against that Chair of Peter, which he acknowledged as an essential endowment of the true Church. Clearly, St. Optatus did not believe in the absolute equality of all the apostles held by modern Eastern Orthodox Christians.

In my next letter, Euthymios, I will show how the Petrine office is necessary for the preservation of orthodoxy in the Church.

At the same time, the other apostles—and their apostolic successors—can be said to have a *subordinate* share in the power of the keys, i.e., under Peter’s supreme leadership, as Jesus also gave them the power “to bind and loose” (Matt 18:15–18).

¹⁴ St. Optatus, *Against the Donatists*, bk. 2, chs. 2, 4.

¹⁵ St. Optatus, *Against the Donatists*, bk. 2, ch. 4.